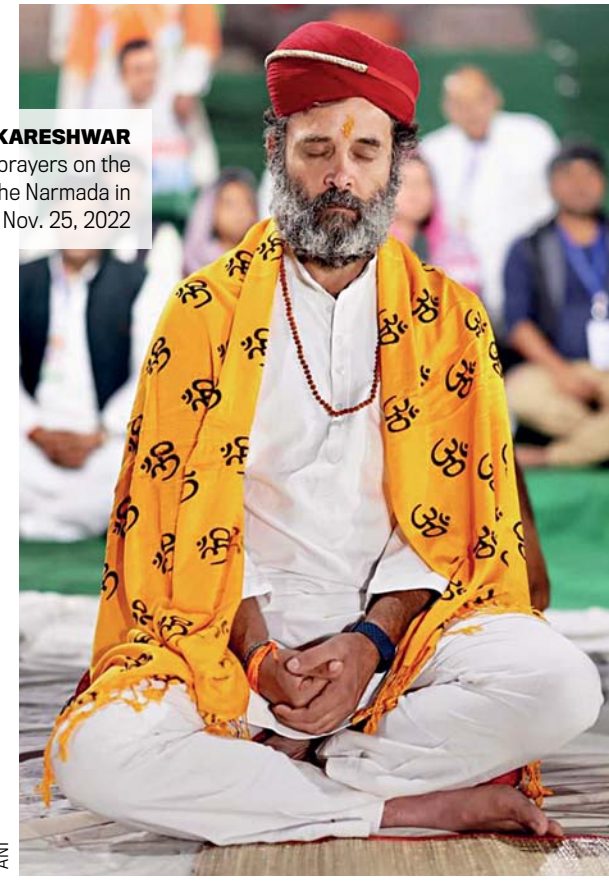


JAI OMKARESHWAR
Rahul offers prayers on the banks of the Narmada in Khandwa, MP, Nov. 25, 2022

ANI

STARING AT THE ABYSS

A definitive verdict on that question will come only after results of the nine state assembly polls in 2023 are announced, including the crucial elections in the states of Karnataka and Madhya Pradesh where the Congress is hoping to make a comeback as well as in Rajasthan and Chhattisgarh where it needs to retain its hold. Wins in these states are vital for the Congress to regain its legitimacy as a national party and arrest the potential slide into political oblivion. Its overall position has never been as bad as it is now. The ignominy began with the 2014 and 2019 general elections, when the party's tally for the first time since Independence dropped drastically to 44 and 52, respectively, in the 543-member Lok Sabha. Rahul Gandhi took the blame for the 2019 debacle, resigned as Congress president soon after, and retreated into a long sulk. A spate of crucial desertions from the party followed, the most notable one being of Jyotiraditya Scindia, who took down the year-old Kamal Nath-led Congress government in MP when he and his followers defected to the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) in March 2020.

RAHUL STILL DOESN'T MINCE HIS WORDS WHEN TALKING OF THE BJP, BUT HIS TONE IS OF A TAPASVI, AS HE CALLS HIMSELF, WILLING TO MAKE SACRIFICES FOR THE GOOD OF SOCIETY

The year also saw growing dissidence within the party, culminating in a letter to interim Congress president Sonia Gandhi by a group of 23 senior leaders, dubbed the G23, demanding that elections be held for a new Congress president, and openly challenging the authority of the Gandhi family. It has been all downhill from there, with the Congress ruling in just two states—Rajasthan and Chhattisgarh—and being the junior partner in one—Jharkhand, on the eve of the yatra. Its performance has been dismal in the series of state elections held in 2022, its tally dropping from 77 to 17 in the Gujarat election, and a complete washout in Uttar Pradesh, winning only two of the 403 seats in the state despite a spirited campaign by Priyanka Gandhi. The Congress failed to prevent the re-election of BJP governments in Assam, Uttarakhand and Goa. Worse, it ceded Punjab to the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP), which won the frontline state with a landslide and reduced the Congress to rubble. Its only consolation came at the end of the year, when it won Himachal Pradesh. Summing up the party's sorry plight, Jairam says, "From 2014 to 2019, the Congress was staring at an abyss. From 2019 onwards, the abyss was staring at us. We saw no light at the end of the tunnel."

It was in May 2022, at the Chintan Shivir in Udaipur, that Sonia Gandhi, as officiating president, announced that the party will set out on a nationwide yatra in what Jairam calls "the last throw of the dice". The party saw it as its now-or-never moment; its critics saw the exercise as the Congress high command's gambit to bring Rahul into the limelight again. Especially as the presidency of the party, for the first time in two decades, now vests with a non-Gandhi, even if the 81-year-old Mallikarjun Kharge is seen as a proxy for the family. Jairam vehemently denies that the yatra was conceived as an image makeover exercise for Rahul Gandhi, saying, "It was not the cause for the yatra, but a consequence of it." Which begs the question why Rahul Gandhi and not a collective of leaders was chosen to lead the BJY. "Why not Rahul?" counters Digvijaya Singh, senior Congress leader, Rajya Sabha MP and a former chief minister of MP, who despite being 75 years old, has walked most of the distance with Rahul. "How many ex-AICC presidents do you have apart from Sonia Gandhi and Rahul? Given their age, you can't expect Kharge or Soniaji to walk the full distance. Other senior leaders had the choice to walk too and many of them did so in their respective states."